

Hair & Appearance at Work

Asserting yourself as you are, without smoothing yourself over

4 psychology approaches · tips & resources — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Asserting yourself as you are, without smoothing yourself over

Natural hair deemed 'unprofessional', remarks about your appearance, implicit pressure to conform to codes not designed for you: for many Black women, appearance at work is a site of tension. Your hair, your style, your body don't have to bend to be legitimate.

This guide validates what you live, helps you assert yourself as you are, and offers strategies — without carrying this burden alone.

Your intention

A situation about your appearance/hair that made you feel judged: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

The burden of having to conform

The implicit demand to 'smooth over' (literally and figuratively) to be accepted wears you down: transforming yourself each morning, doubting yourself, ending up internalizing that 'my hair isn't professional'.

Understanding that this norm is biased — not you — is freeing.

Example

From straightening her hair 'to look serious', Aïcha was exhausted. Realizing the norm was biased relieved her.

What I impose on myself

What do you change about your appearance to 'look professional'? What does it cost you?

The norm, not me

Separate: what's a genuinely useful code / what's a biased norm that excludes you.

→ *The norm is biased — not my hair, not me.*

The internalized thoughts

'I must straighten to be taken seriously', 'my hair bothers people': these thoughts, from biased norms, aren't truths about your worth.

Questioning them gives you back the freedom to be yourself.

Example

Sure she wouldn't be taken seriously 'natural', Nia tested it — and was treated exactly the same, plus more at ease.

Internalized-thoughts journal

Note: the thought ('I must...') · where it comes from · a fairer version.

Reframe

Turn 'my hair isn't professional' into 'professionalism is my work — not my hairstyle'.

→ *Professionalism is my work — not my hairstyle.*

Asserting yourself as you are

Your appearance takes nothing from your competence. Conforming should never be the price of your legitimacy: choosing what feels good to you is an act of self-respect.

You have the right to be fully yourself at work.

Example

By owning her natural hair, Léa gained confidence — and became, without seeking it, a role model for others.

What feels good to me

Write the appearance/hairstyle that makes you feel like you and good — for you, not to reassure others.

My legitimacy

List 3 proofs that your competence has nothing to do with your appearance.

→ *My appearance takes nothing from my worth — I have the right to be me.*

Strategies & rights

Concretely: choose your battles, prepare responses to remarks, know your rights (hair/appearance-based discrimination is recognized in several countries), and lean on networks and role models.

You don't have to carry this burden alone.

Example

To 'your hair is... unusual', Fatou calmly replies 'thanks, it's my hair' — and moves on. The awkwardness switches sides.

My responses

Prepare 2 responses to frequent remarks (from light to a reframe).

My supports & rights

Note: 1 network/role model who inspires you · and learn your rights if you're penalized.

→ *I have responses, rights and supports — I don't carry this alone.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Your hair/appearance don't have to conform to be professional.
- What you live (remarks, pressure) is real — and it's discrimination if it penalizes you.
- Choose what feels good to you, not what reassures others.
- Prepare calm responses to remarks.
- Learn your rights (appearance/hair discrimination is recognized in several countries).
- Surround yourself with role models and networks — you don't have to carry this alone.

To fill in

Remarks journal

The remark	My feeling	My ready response

What feels good to me

My own choice	Why

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — See the burden of having to conform.

Week 2 — Question the internalized thoughts.

Week 3 — Assert myself as I am.

Week 4 — Strategies, responses & rights.

Your plan in 3 lines

- What I allow myself (for me):
- My ready response to a remark:
- The network/role model who inspires me:

TO CLOSE

**Your appearance takes nothing from your worth —
assert yourself as you are.**

Your appearance takes nothing from your worth.

What you experience around your appearance and hair at work is real: this guide never minimizes it. It's a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy or legal advice. If you're going through a hard time, reach out to a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.